

BALTIC STATES AND BELARUS

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THE THREE Baltic states of Estonia, Latvia, and Lithuania occupy a small area on the Baltic Sea coast to the west of the Russian Federation. Belarus, formerly known as "White Russia", sits between Russia, Poland, and Ukraine. All four countries were former Soviet republics; in 1991, after the break-up of the Soviet Union, they declared independence. Since then, they have suffered high inflation and environmental problems, but are now working to form a trade link between eastern and western Europe.

Physical features

The Baltic states have a flat landscape of plains and low hills, with forests and swampy marshes. There are thousands of rivers and lakes, of which the largest is Peipus, at 3,626 sq km (1,400 sq miles), shared between Estonia and Russia.



Baltic coast and islands

Estonia, Latvia, and Lithuania all have coasts and ports on the Baltic Sea, and ice covers much of the sea in winter. Estonia has the longest coastline, and the country includes more than 1,500 islands that form a barrier protecting the Gulf of Riga.

Forests

Dense deciduous and coniferous forests cover between 30 and 40 per cent of the Baltic region. Belarus is dominated by lakes and thick forests full of wildlife such as deer and mink. The east of Latvia is forested.



Forested Ganja River valley, Latvia

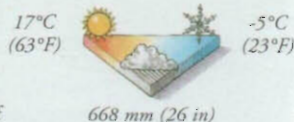


Pripet Marshes

Covering a vast area of southern Belarus, the Pripet Marshes are the biggest wetland area in Europe. They stretch for 40,000 sq km (15,000 sq miles), and are fed by several rivers including the Byerazino and Dnieper. The soils of the Pripet are clay or sandy, and large areas are waterlogged.

Regional climate

Estonia, Lithuania, Latvia, and Belarus have cold winters and cool, wet summers, because of their location on the Baltic Sea. Heavy snow falls during the winter throughout the region, particularly in Belarus.



Cultural diversity

Estonia, Latvia, and Belarus have large Russian populations, who were resettled in the Baltic states under communist rule. This has caused some racial tension with ethnic peoples in Estonia and Latvia. In Belarus, where most people are Russian speakers, and Lithuania, where 80 per cent are ethnic Lithuanians, there is social harmony.

Folk dancer, Estonia